

The Road to the Republic of Turkey: 1919-1923

The period from the beginning of the Turkish War of Independence to the proclamation of the Republic was the key era in which Turkey secured its political independence and established a new state based on national sovereignty.

19 May 1919 - Beginning of the National Struggle

Mustafa Kemal Pasha's arrival in Samsun on 19 May 1919 is widely regarded as the starting point of the Turkish National Struggle. The Amasya Circular that followed emphasized that the integrity of the homeland and the independence of the nation were in danger, and declared that the nation's independence would be saved by the determination and decision of the nation itself. The Erzurum and Sivas Congresses later helped unite regional resistance movements around a common national objective and strengthened the Representative Committee.

23 April 1920 - Opening of the Grand National Assembly

After the occupation of Istanbul and the end of the Ottoman Chamber of Deputies, it was decided to convene a new assembly with extraordinary powers in Ankara. The Grand National Assembly of Turkey opened in Ankara on 23 April 1920. Ankara therefore became the political and legal center of the National Struggle. The Assembly directed the War of Independence and became the main institution of the emerging political order based on national sovereignty. The Constitution of 1921, adopted on 20 January 1921, further expressed the principle that sovereignty belonged to the nation.

1921 - Battle of Sakarya

The Battle of Sakarya, fought from 23 August to 13 September 1921, became one of the major turning points of the Turkish War of Independence. Following the Turkish victory, the Grand National Assembly granted Mustafa Kemal Pasha the title of 'Gazi' and the rank of Field Marshal on 19 September 1921. The victory contributed to a shift in military initiative toward the Turkish side and strengthened the diplomatic position of the independence movement.

1922 - Great Offensive and Abolition of the Sultanate

The Great Offensive began on 26 August 1922 and achieved a decisive victory with the Battle of the Commander-in-Chief on 30 August. The Turkish army continued its advance and entered Izmir on 9 September 1922. As the military struggle approached its end, the Grand National Assembly abolished the Ottoman Sultanate on 1 November 1922. This decision was a critical step in ending Ottoman political sovereignty and shaping the new state around the principle of national sovereignty. The Mudanya Armistice then marked the transition from armed conflict to a new diplomatic phase.

24 July 1923 - Treaty of Lausanne

Following negotiations between Turkey and the Allied Powers, the Treaty of Lausanne was signed on 24 July 1923. The treaty was a major milestone in the international recognition of the new Turkish state. Important questions involving borders, capitulations, minorities, debts, and the postwar settlement were addressed during the negotiations. Lausanne is generally regarded as the diplomatic settlement that confirmed internationally the independence achieved through the military struggle.

13 and 29 October 1923 - Capital and Republic

On 13 October 1923, Ankara was officially designated as the capital of Turkey. On 29 October 1923, a constitutional amendment adopted by the Grand National Assembly proclaimed the Republic, and Mustafa Kemal Pasha was elected the first President of the Republic of Turkey. The National Struggle that had begun in 1919 thus entered a new stage with the formal establishment of a state based on national sovereignty. The republican system made the principle that sovereignty belonged to the nation, rather than to a dynasty, the foundation of the new political order.

Short Timeline

19 May 1919	Mustafa Kemal Pasha arrives in Samsun
23 April 1920	Grand National Assembly of Turkey opens
30 August 1922	Battle of the Commander-in-Chief
1 November 1922	Abolition of the Sultanate
24 July 1923	Treaty of Lausanne is signed
29 October 1923	Proclamation of the Republic

Presentation question: On what date did the Grand National Assembly of Turkey open? **Answer:** 23 April 1920.

Source note: The dates and major events summarized here are consistent with standard official histories published by the Grand National Assembly of Turkey. This one-page document was prepared for educational and presentation purposes.